

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Deuteronomy

Deuteronomy

God first revealed Israel's national "constitution" (the basic laws that guided the nation) to Moses at Mount Sinai (Exodus 20–23). Now Moses, Israel's great leader, was about to die. God had chosen a younger man, Joshua, to take his place, but Joshua had not yet been fully tested as a leader.

God had rescued Israel from slavery in Egypt and had miraculously cared for them during 40 years in the wilderness. The Israelites were now ready to enter the land God had promised them. However, powerful enemies already lived there and would oppose them.

God had been faithful to Israel in the past, but the future still seemed uncertain. Deuteronomy tells how Israel renewed its covenant (binding agreement) with God. This covenant would guide the nation and lead them to God's blessings throughout the rest of their history.

Setting

Forty years after leaving Egypt, the Israelites arrived at the plains of Moab, across the Jordan River from Jericho. After 40 years in the wilderness, they were ready to cross the Jordan River, defeat the Canaanite nations, and settle in the land God had promised to Abraham. Before this happened, however, God would renew his covenant with them.

Moses knew that he would die before leading the Israelites into the land God had promised them. Before his death, he needed to remind the people of the covenant that God had given through him.

God had first made this covenant with Israel 38 years earlier at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19–24), when the people were on their way to Canaan. Now Israel was about to become a settled nation in its own land. Because of this, the covenant needed to be restated and expanded.

The book of Deuteronomy is this restatement of the covenant.

Summary

Deuteronomy records the final message from Moses to the tribes of Israel. The book contains stories, appeals, warnings, instructions, and promises of blessings or curses based on whether Israel remains faithful to God.

Deuteronomy is written in the form of a treaty, using features commonly found in agreements between nations. It is similar to treaties from the ancient Near East, especially those found in Hittite records. By using this familiar legal and literary form, Moses explains God's purposes to Israel in a way the people could understand.

The formal structure of Deuteronomy helps us understand its theological message. As a covenant text, it shows the seriousness of God's promises and Israel's responsibility to obey the covenant's requirements. Through Israel's obedience, they would experience the blessings God had promised.

As a farewell speech, the book is also connected to a specific time and place in Israel's history.

The following outline shows how Deuteronomy can be understood as a covenant document:

- 1:1–5 Preamble to the covenant
- 1:6–4:49 Historical background
- 5:1–26:15 Covenant requirements
- 26:16–29:1 Blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience
- 29:2–30:20 Review of the covenant and choice between life and death
- 31:1–29 Writing and preserving of the covenant document
- 31:30–32:43 Witnesses to the covenant

The outline in the book of Deuteronomy reflects its structure both as a covenant text and as a farewell speech made up of a series of sermons.

Author

Jewish and Christian traditions have long taught that Moses wrote Deuteronomy. Both the Old Testament and the New Testament identify Moses as the book's author (see 1 Kings 2:3; 2 Kings 14:6; 2 Chronicles 25:4; Ezra 3:2; Matthew 19:7; Mark 12:19; Luke 20:28; Acts 3:22–23; Romans 10:19; 1 Corinthians 9:9).

However, over the past two hundred years, many scholars have argued that Moses did not write Deuteronomy. Some identify Deuteronomy with the scroll found in the temple during the reign of King Josiah (around 621 BC; see 2 Kings 22:8–20). They argue that the book was written or completed around that time. Other scholars believe that editors added material later, including during or after the Israelite exile in Babylon (538 BC and later).

Archaeologists have discovered Hittite treaty texts from the Late Bronze Age (1500–1200 BC), the period when Moses is traditionally believed to have lived.

These texts share several features with Deuteronomy and support the view that the book was written at an early date.

Some scholars compare Deuteronomy to Assyrian treaty texts from the seventh century BC, which are closer in time to King Josiah. However, the Hittite texts are more similar to Deuteronomy in both structure and content than the Assyrian texts. For this reason, some scholars believe it is less likely that Deuteronomy was written during the later period.

In summary, the traditional view that Moses wrote most of Deuteronomy is a reasonable conclusion. Some parts were added later by editors, such as the account of the death of Moses (Deuteronomy 34:5–12). For more information, see the Genesis Book Introduction under “Author.”

Literary Form

The structure of Deuteronomy is similar to that of other treaty documents used between nations during the time of the exodus and the conquest of Canaan. Some of these treaties were made between equal nations. Others were made between a stronger ruler and a weaker people.

In this second type of treaty, called a suzerain-vassal treaty, the stronger ruler (the suzerain, or “great king”) gave commands and made promises to the weaker people (the vassals). In return, the vassals were expected to obey completely.

Deuteronomy is a suzerain-vassal treaty between God and Israel. God brought the Israelites out of slavery in Egypt and chose them to be his people and servants. He took the initiative in this relationship, established the terms of the covenant, and promised blessings if Israel obeyed. He also warned of judgment if the nation disobeyed.

By using the suzerain-vassal treaty format, Moses shows that Deuteronomy is a covenant document. God chose Israel to be his special people. The covenant did not make them God’s people, because God had already identified them as his people before the exodus (Exodus 4:22–23). Instead, the covenant set out how God’s people were to live. By reviewing the covenant with this generation of Israelites, Moses prepared them to enter the promised land as God’s covenant people.

Meaning and Message

The covenant is the central theme of Deuteronomy and may be one of the main themes of the entire Old Testament. Through the covenant, the Lord joined himself to Israel in a special relationship. The covenant

declared that the Lord was Israel’s God, that Israel was his people, and that their relationship would accomplish God’s plan of redemption (his work to save and restore people).

This great privilege also brought great responsibility. Would Israel live in a way that allowed them to carry out their mission? What standards of behavior would help them fulfill their calling?

Israel was free to accept or reject God’s covenant (Exodus 19:7–8). After accepting it, the people would experience either blessings or curses, depending on whether they obeyed or disobeyed God’s commands (28:1–6, 15–19).

Even when Israel disobeyed, there was still hope. If the nation repented, returned to the Lord, and renewed its covenant relationship with him, God would restore them (30:1–10; see also Leviticus 26:40–45).

This covenant did not make Israel God’s people. God had already made that promise to Abraham when he promised to make his descendants into a nation (Genesis 17:1–8). The covenant at Mount Sinai gave Israel the privilege of serving the Lord as a kingdom of priests (Exodus 19:4–6).

Deuteronomy restates the terms of this covenant. If Israel remained faithful in its role as a “a kingdom of priests” and God’s “holy nation,” it would be a means through which God’s blessings would reach the world.

The Israelites were God’s chosen people. God had made promises to their ancestors, and he fulfilled those promises through the exodus from Egypt and the formation of the nation. He was now ready to establish Israel in the promised land through the conquest of Canaan and to continue working through them until his purposes were fulfilled.

Deuteronomy sets out the principles for faithful living and service to God. These principles would help Israel remain faithful to the Lord as they took part in his purposes. Israel had the great honor of working with Almighty God as he carried out his plan for all nations.